SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #89 · THE BIBLE

“Any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that encourages “claiming” verses for health, wealth, or success. Popular verses on posters taken out of context. Desperation for a specific outcome. Disappointment when a “claimed” promise did not come true. Misunderstanding the difference between promises and principles.

What Scripture teaches

God’s promises are true, and we can trust them. But not every verse is a promise for every situation, and God’s promises are not tools for getting whatever we want. Jeremiah 29:11 was spoken to exiles in Babylon who would wait seventy years. James says we sometimes do not receive because we ask with wrong motives. We pray according to God’s will. Rightly understood, His promises give hope, but they serve His purposes, not ours.

> *“For this is what the LORD says: ‘When Babylon’s seventy years are complete, I will attend to you and confirm My promise to restore you to this place. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope.’”*
> **(Jeremiah 29:10–11)**.

Also see

> “And when you do ask, you do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, that you may squander it on your pleasures” **(James 4:3)**.

> “And this is the confidence that we have before Him: If we ask anything according to His will, He hears us” **(1 John 5:14)**.

> “Make every effort to present yourself approved to God, an unashamed workman who accurately handles the word of truth” **(2 Timothy 2:15)**.

> “I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” **(Philippians 4:12–13)**.

Common self-statements

- God promised this, so He has to do it.
- I’m claiming this verse for my situation.
- If it didn’t happen, I didn’t claim it right.
- Every verse is a promise to me.
- Philippians 4:13 means I can do anything I want.
- God owes me what the verse says.

Common logical errors

- **Taking verses out of context:** Applying a promise without knowing who it was for.
- **Magical thinking:** Believing that “claiming” a verse forces an outcome.

- **Self-centered reading:** Using Scripture to get what you want rather than to know God.
- **Disappointment-driven thinking:** Concluding God failed when a misapplied promise didn't happen.

Challenging questions

- Who was Jeremiah 29:11 first spoken to, and how long did they wait?
- Is this verse a promise, a principle, or a description?
- What does James 4:3 say about wrong motives?
- Am I asking according to God's will or mine?
- What did Paul mean by "I can do all things" in Philippians 4?
- Has God failed me, or did I misunderstand the verse?
- What promises of God am I sure apply to me in Christ?

Truth summary

> Not every verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want. God's promises are true, but I need to understand them in context and pray according to His will. His promises serve His purposes and give me hope, even in hard seasons. I can trust what He has truly promised in Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Scripture/Word
- Prayer, Answers to
- Will of God
- Trust
- Truth

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who was Jeremiah 29:11 first for?
- ☐ Is this a promise, principle, or description?
- ☐ What does James say about wrong motives?
- ☐ Am I asking for God's will or mine?
- ☐ What did Paul mean by "all things"?
- ☐ What promises in Christ are sure for me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's promises are true when rightly understood.
- ☐ I pray according to God's will.
- ☐ God's promises serve His purposes, not my wishes.
- ☐ I can read promises in their context.
- ☐ God's plans for His people include hope, even through waiting.
- ☐ I can be content in Christ in every situation.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Jeremiah 29:10–11**
  "For this is what the LORD says: 'When Babylon's seventy years are complete, I will attend to you and confirm My promise to restore you to this place. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope.'"

- [ ] **James 4:3**
  "And when you do ask, you do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, that you may squander it on your pleasures."

- [ ] **1 John 5:14**
  "And this is the confidence that we have before Him: If we ask anything according to His will, He hears us."

- [ ] **2 Timothy 2:15**
  "Make every effort to present yourself approved to God, an unashamed workman who accurately handles the word of truth."

- [ ] **Philippians 4:12–13**
  "I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. I am accustomed to any and every situation—to being filled and being hungry, to having plenty and having need. I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **True promises list:** Each day, write one promise God has made to all believers in Christ, with its reference.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 1 John 5:14 becomes: "And this is the confidence that **Sarah** has before Him: If **she** asks anything according to His will, He hears **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Prayer, Answers to" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Jeremiah 29:1–14,** and write who the promise was for and how long they had to wait.
- ☐ **Read Philippians 4:10–13,** and write what "all things" meant for Paul.
- ☐ **Make a list of promises given to all believers,** such as Romans 8:1, 8:28, and Hebrews 13:5.
- ☐ **When praying for something you want,** add, "Your will be done."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One promise I studied in context
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that Your promises are true. Help me reject the idea that any verse is a promise I can claim for whatever I want. Teach me to understand Your Word in context, to pray according to Your will, and to trust You through every season. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.